# Explaining with precision

Plan, sequence and rehearse the explanation

Use precise explanation when the content is correct but the message is too long, unclear or difficult to follow. Plan what to say, what to show and what to leave out.

## How to do it well

**1 Define the core idea.** Write the smallest accurate explanation that makes the intended relationship clear.

**2 Sequence the components.** Introduce necessary terms and prerequisites before adding the dependent idea; use a concrete example.

**3 Align the representation.** Plan the diagram, worked step or demonstration and where students should look at each moment.

**4 Deliver and pause.** Use concise language, check listening and allow reading or processing before introducing another component.

**5 Capture and rehearse.** Leave a useful summary, guide a related attempt and repair the precise point the responses reveal.

## What this sounds like

“This arrow shows the transfer, not the store. Watch the arrow while I explain the movement. Now tell me what the arrow represents before we consider a new example.”

**Classroom example.** A Science teacher rehearses a concise explanation of a particle relationship, chooses a simple diagram and plans two pauses. Students first retrieve a key statement, then apply it in a new situation. A common error leads to a focused contrast. The explanation remains precise rather than expanding into several distracting related topics.

## Top tips that make the technique work

**Rehearse the difficult sentence.** A brief rehearsal often exposes vague terms, unnecessary detours and an overloaded sequence.

**Funnel attention.** Align your words, pointing and visual display so students know which feature matters now.

**Use consistent terminology.** Switching casually between labels can create extra interpretation work for novices.

**Capture the key idea.** A stable sentence, diagram or checklist supports early practice after the spoken explanation ends.

**Check receipt and application separately.** A listening check and a fresh example answer different questions about the explanation.

## Do and avoid

| Do | Avoid |
|---|---|
| Plan a concise sequence and useful representation. | Adding interesting detail that distracts from the main idea. |
| Pause between coherent chunks. | Reading dense slide text aloud while students try to read it. |

## Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED — Explaining With Precision